

German Adjective Suffixes & Prefixes

The master guide to German adjective formation: Native derivational suffixes (-ig, -lich, -isch, -bar, -sam, -haft, -los, -reich...), intensifying & negative prefixes (un-, ur-, miss-, erz-, hoch-...), and foreign international suffixes.

The Core Adjective Suffix Distinctions:

- ig:** Having the property or physical presence (*sonnig* = sunny, *steinig* = stony).
- lich:** Characteristic of, recurring periodicity (*täglich* = daily), or softened quality (*rötlich* = reddish).
- isch:** Geographic origin / language (*spanisch*), or often negative/derogatory behavior (*kindisch* = childish vs. *kindlich* = childlike).
- bar:** Passive possibility (English '-able / -ible'): *trinkbar* = drinkable, *machbar* = doable.

Opposing & Graduating Suffix Pairs:

- voll vs. -los:** Full of vs. devoid of (*hoffnungsvoll* = hopeful ↔ *hoffnungslos* = hopeless).
- reich vs. -arm:** Abundant in vs. scarce in (*vitaminreich* = rich in vitamins ↔ *vitaminarm* = low vitamin).
- fähig vs. -unfähig:** Capable of (*kontaktfähig* = sociable ↔ *unfähig*).

Adjective Prefixes:

- un- (Negation):** *unglücklich*, *unmöglich* | **ur- (Primordial / Extreme):** *uralt*, *urgemütlich*.

1. Essential Native Adjective Suffixes (Germanische Adjektivsuffixe)

Suffix	Semantic Meaning & Grammatical Derivation	High-Yield Examples & Definitions
-ig	Possessing a quality, made of, physical attribute (Most common native suffix)	sonnig (sunny), ruhig (calm), mutig (brave), traurig (sad), fleißig (diligent), billig (cheap), schmutzig (dirty), giftig (poisonous)
-lich	1. Periodic/Time (<i>monatlich</i>) 2. Tendency (<i>höflich</i>) 3. Softening colors (<i>bläulich</i>) 4. Feasibility (<i>möglich</i>)	freundlich (friendly), täglich (daily), pünktlich (punctual), glücklich (happy), menschlich (human), gemütlich (cozy), herzlich (cordial)
-isch	1. Nationalities & languages 2. Scientific/objective 3. Character trait (often pejorative/critical)	deutsch (German), typisch (typical), logisch (logical), kritisch (critical), neidisch (envious), egoistisch (selfish), kindisch (childish)
-bar	Passive capability / feasibility (Corresponds directly to English -able / -ible)	machbar (doable), essbar (edible), trinkbar (drinkable), bezahlbar (affordable), sichtbar (visible), wunderbar (wonderful), brauchbar (usable)
-sam	Inclination towards, prone to doing, passive endurance or disposition	langsam (slow), einsam (lonely), sparsam (thrifty/economical), aufmerksam (attentive), gemeinsam (together/shared), angenehm (pleasant)
-haft	Bearing the nature of, full of, resembling, manifesting (English '-like / -ish')	lebhaft (lively), traumhaft (dreamlike/gorgeous), schmerzhaft (painful), fehlerhaft (flawed), wahrhaftig (truthful), dauerhaft (lasting)
-los	Lack of, complete absence, deprivation (English -less)	arbeitslos (unemployed), kostenlos (free of charge), sprachlos (speechless), schlaflos (sleepless), hilflos (helpless), endlos (endless)
-voll	Full of, characterized by an abundance of quality (English -ful)	liebevoll (loving), wertvoll (valuable), sinnvoll (meaningful), respektvoll (respectful), qualvoll (agonizing), wundervoll (wonderful)
-reich	Abundant in, rich in supply/content	erfolgreich (successful), hilfreich (helpful), einflussreich (influential), vitaminreich (vitamin-rich), kinderreich (with many kids)
-arm	Poor in, low in content, lacking substance	kalorienarm (low-calorie), fettarm (low-fat), schadstoffarm (low-emission), wasserarm (arid/dry), chancenarm (low-opportunity)
-wert / -würdig	Worthy of, deserving of an action	sehenswert (worth seeing), lebenswert (worth living), empfehlenswert (recommendable), glaubwürdig (credible), vertrauenswürdig (trustworthy)
-fähig	Capable of performing or enduring	leistungsfähig (efficient/productive), teamfähig (team-oriented), anpassungsfähig (adaptable), geschäftsfähig (legally competent)

2. Adjective Prefixes (Intensifying, Negating & Modifying)

German adjective prefixes instantly invert meanings or scale adjectives to extreme intensity.

Präfix	Semantic Function	Examples & Meanings
un-	Direct negation (English <i>un-</i> / <i>in-</i> / <i>non-</i>)	unmöglich (impossible), unglücklich (unhappy), ungeduldig (impatient), unbekannt (unknown), unhöflich (impolite), unwichtig (unimportant)
ur-	1. Primordial/ancient origin 2. Extreme degree / supreme intensity	uralt (ancient / super old), urgemütlich (super cozy), urkomisch (hilarious), urplötzlich (all of a sudden), urtypisch (archetypal)
miss-	Wrong, flawed, unfavorable, negative assessment	missmutig (bad-tempered), missgünstig (spiteful/jealous), misstrauisch (distrustful), missverständlich (ambiguous/misleading)
erz-	Extreme degree, ultra, staunch, archenemy intensity	erzkonservativ (ultra-conservative), erzfaul (extremely lazy), erzrivalisierend (arch-rivaling), erzdumm (monumentally stupid)
hoch-	Highly, extremely, supreme level of quality	hochintelligent (highly intelligent), hochmodern (cutting-edge), hochgiftig (highly toxic), hochinteressant (fascinating)
grund-	Fundamental, at the deepest root, inherently	grundlegend (fundamental), grundverschieden (fundamentally different), grundehrlich (thoroughly honest), grundfalsch (totally wrong)
brand-	Extremely, blazing, fiery (Intensifier)	brandneu (brand new), brandaktuell (hot off the press / latest), brandgefährlich (blazingly dangerous)
bitter-	Extreme bitterness / severity of condition	bitterkalt (bitterly cold), bitterböse (fierce / furious), bitterarm (destitute / extremely poor)

3. Foreign / International Adjective Suffixes (Fremdwortsuffixe)

Academic, scientific, and cultural German borrows heavily from Latin, Greek, and French adjective suffixes.

Suffix	Linguistic Function & Origin	Examples & Cognates
-al / -ell	Relating to, pertaining to a formal system (Latin <i>-alis</i> / <i>-ellus</i>)	international , ideal , global , aktuell (current), kulturell (cultural), speziell (special), offiziell (official)
-iv	Active tendency, qualitative disposition (Latin <i>-ivus</i>)	aktiv (active), kreativ (creative), intensiv (intense), positiv (positive), aggressiv (aggressive), effektiv (effective)
-ant / -ent	Present participle quality, state of being (Latin <i>-ans</i> / <i>-ens</i>)	elegant (elegant), tolerant (tolerant), intelligent (intelligent), kompetent (competent), konsequent (consistent)
-ös / -ose	Characterized by abundant substance / medical / poetic (French <i>-eux</i>)	nervös (nervous), religiös (religious), ominös (ominous), skrupellos (unscrupulous), monströs (monstrous)
-är / -iel	Categorical designation / sector (French <i>-aire</i> / <i>-iel</i>)	populär (popular), familiär (informal/family-like), finanziell (financial), potenziell (potential)